A 90-MINUTE WORKSHOP

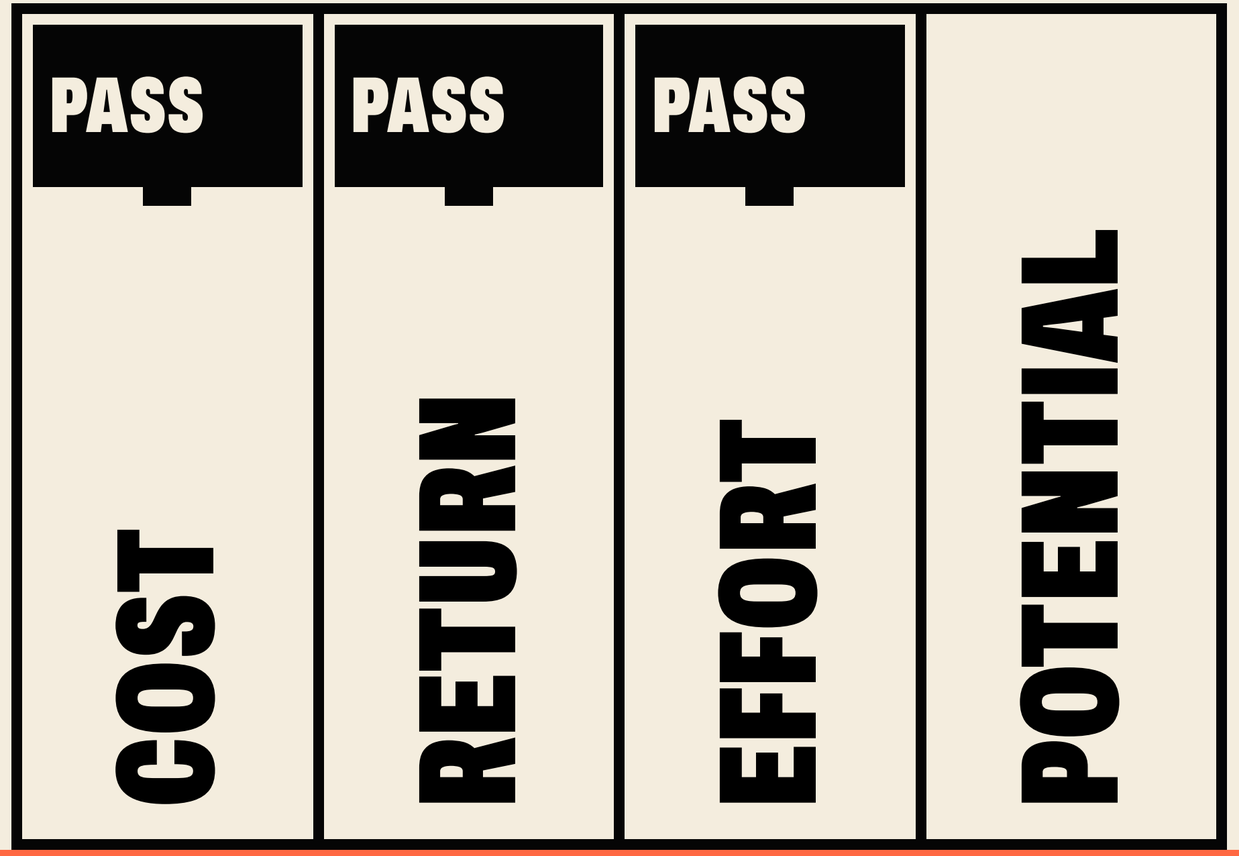
WAYPOINT · NOAI 2026 · NEW ORLEANS

THE MOST VALUABLE AI SKILL IS SAYING

Screening AI use cases for real return.

Dustin T Hughes

VP of Technology, Laborde Products



TAKE A WORKSHEET AND A PEN

STARTS **2:30**

YOUR BEST AI IDEA IS PROBABLY WRONG.

The boring one you didn't pitch is probably

WORTH THOUSANDS.

A 90-MINUTE WORKSHOP

THE MOST VALUABLE AI SKILL IS SAYING NO

Screening AI use cases for real return.

Dustin T Hughes
VP of Technology, Laborde Products

WAYPOINT · NOAI 2026 · NEW ORLEANS

WHEN	TIME	ROOM
FRIDAY NOV 13, 2026	2:30–4:00 PM 90 MINUTES	EDUCATION CENTER

“~~Information theory~~ AI OUR EDIT
has, in the last few years, become something of a scientific bandwagon.”

— CLAUDE SHANNON, THE BANDWAGON, 1956

1956.

“Seldom do more than a few of nature’s secrets give way at one time.”

— CLAUDE SHANNON, THE BANDWAGON, 1956

I say no for a living.

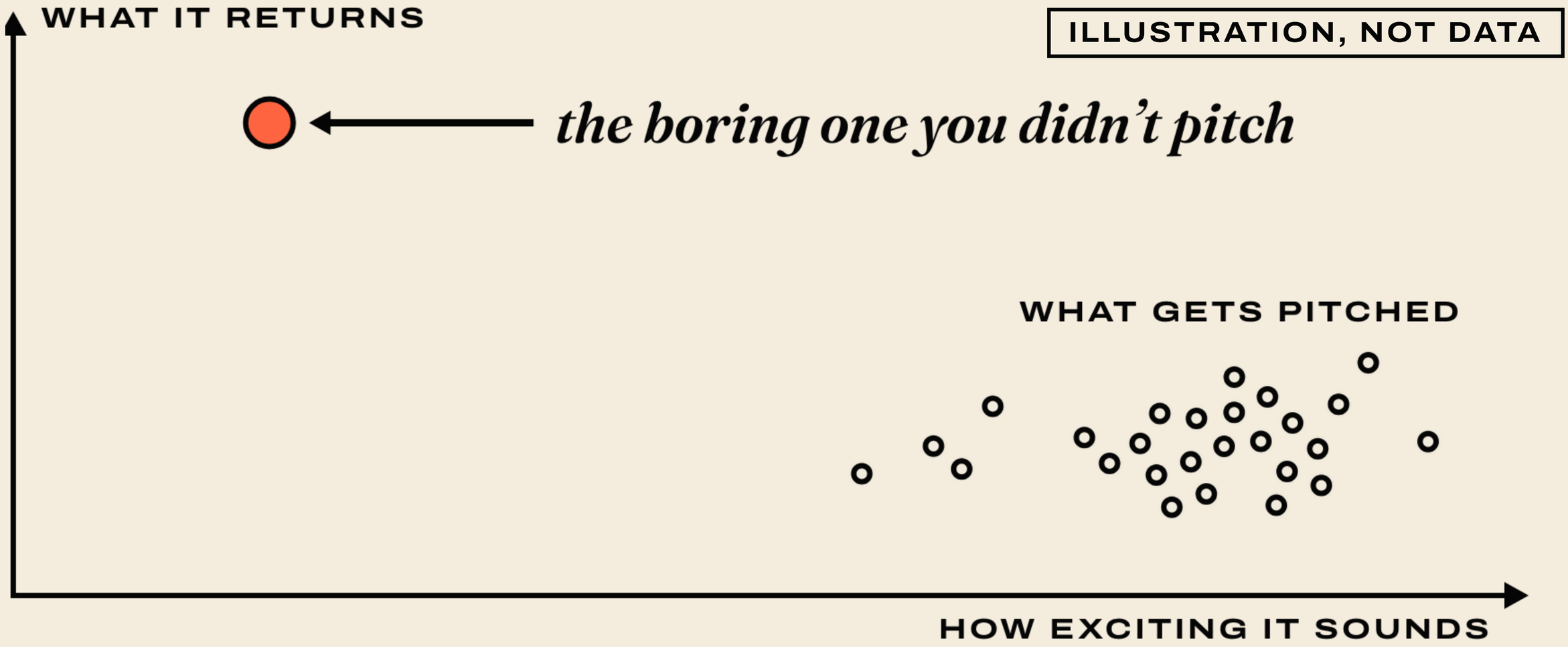
PEOPLE	LOCATIONS	BUILDING SOFTWARE	AI SINCE
95	3	25 years	2013

THE WAYPOINT STANDARD

1	2	3	4
THE TASK	THE PROMPT	THE OUTPUT	THE TIME SAVED

A win only counts with all four.

EXCITEMENT IS NOT A BUSINESS CASE.



Illustration, not data. The dots are made up to show a pattern. Nothing on this slide was measured.

IN THE NEXT 90 MINUTES

1 Inventory two weeks of real work

2 Pick three

3 Four gates

4 The math picks

5 Watch one get built

You leave with one use case worth doing, and two you can stop thinking about.

THE FOUR GATES

EXAMPLE

Any no ends it.

PASS

GATE 1

COST

What does it cost to run?



CARRIED FORWARD

GATE 2

RETURN

What comes back: cash sooner, or more work done?

NO

STOPS HERE

GATE 3

EFFORT

What does it take to build it and keep it alive?

NOT YET

GATE 4

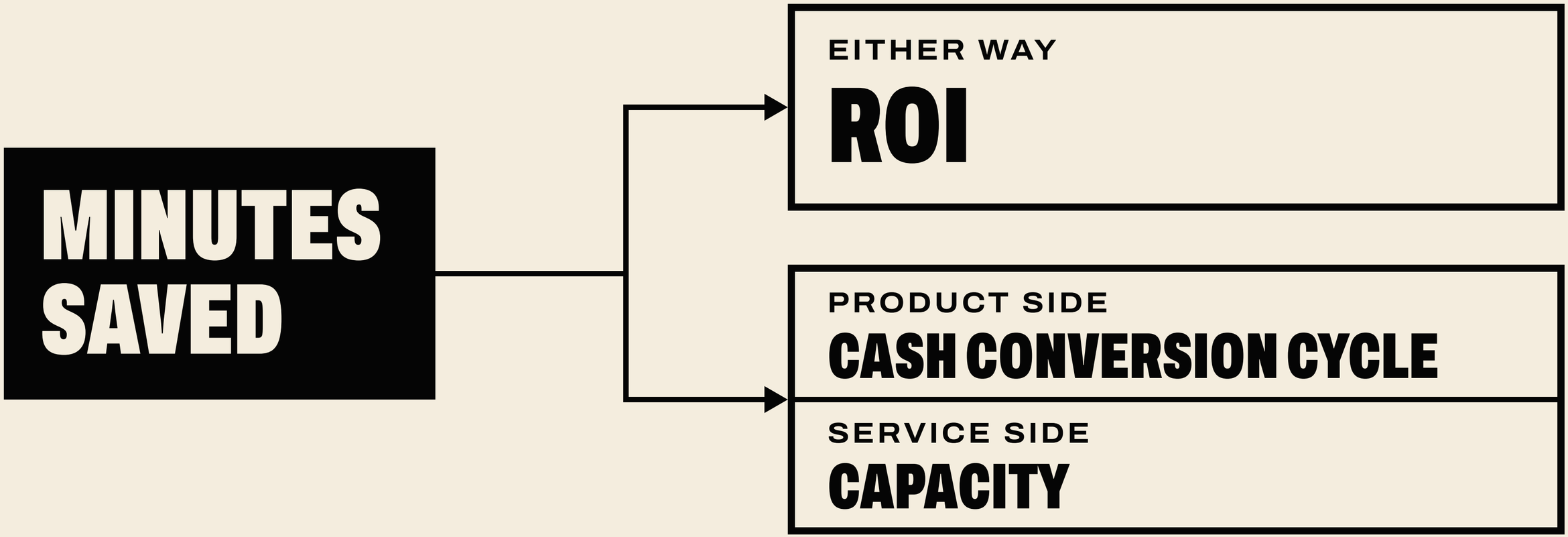
POTENTIAL

If it works, how far does it grow?

NOT YET

Minutes are the raw material.

Money is what they turn into.

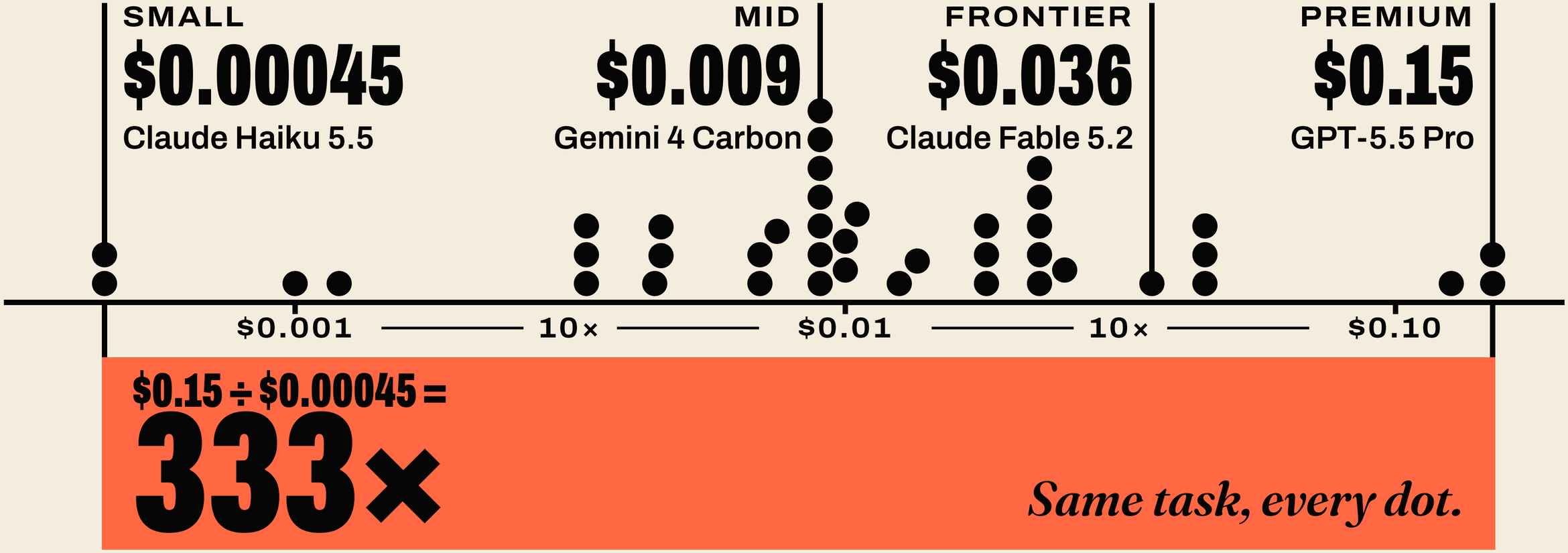


GATE 1 · COST

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

WHAT DOES IT COST TO RUN?

41 MODELS · PRICE PER TASK · 2,000 TOKENS IN, 500 OUT · LOG SCALE



$0.15 ÷ $0.00045 =

333×

Same task, every dot.

Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · 41 of 50 models priced (5 blank and 4 at $0 left out) · GPT-5.5 Pro and GPT-5.4 Pro tie at $0.15 · Claude Haiku 5.5 and GPT-6 Luna tie at $0.00045

FOR ONE PERSON, COST ALMOST NEVER SAYS NO.

18 seconds

what the dearest model has to save to pay for itself, at $30 an hour

EXAMPLE RATE · DRAG FROM $20 TO $150 AN HOUR

$30

FRONTIER MODEL

4.3 seconds

Claude Fable 5.2 · $0.036 a task

SMALL MODEL

0.05 seconds

Claude Haiku 5.5 · $0.00045 a task

Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · GPT-5.5 Pro and GPT-5.4 Pro tie at $0.15 · one task = 2,000 tokens in, 500 out

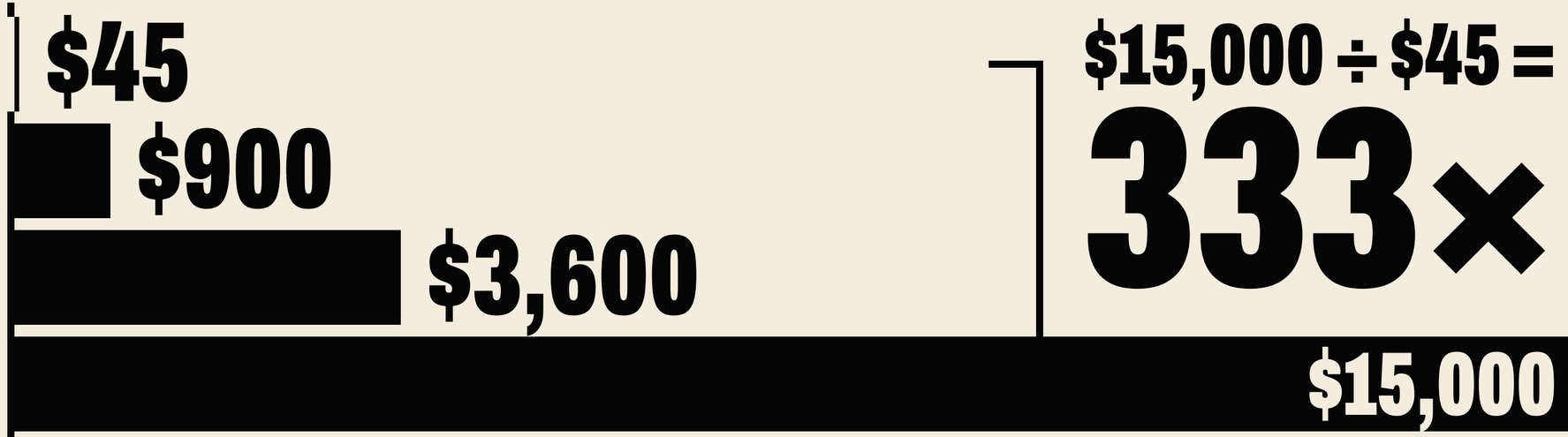
GATE 1 · COST · RECORD SCALE

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

100,000 RECORDS. SAME TASK.

1 | 1,000 | 100,000 | 1,000,000

COST OF THE WHOLE BATCH
US DOLLARS · DRAWN TO SCALE



$15,000 ÷ $45 =

333×

PLAIN CODE

≈ $0

No bar to draw.

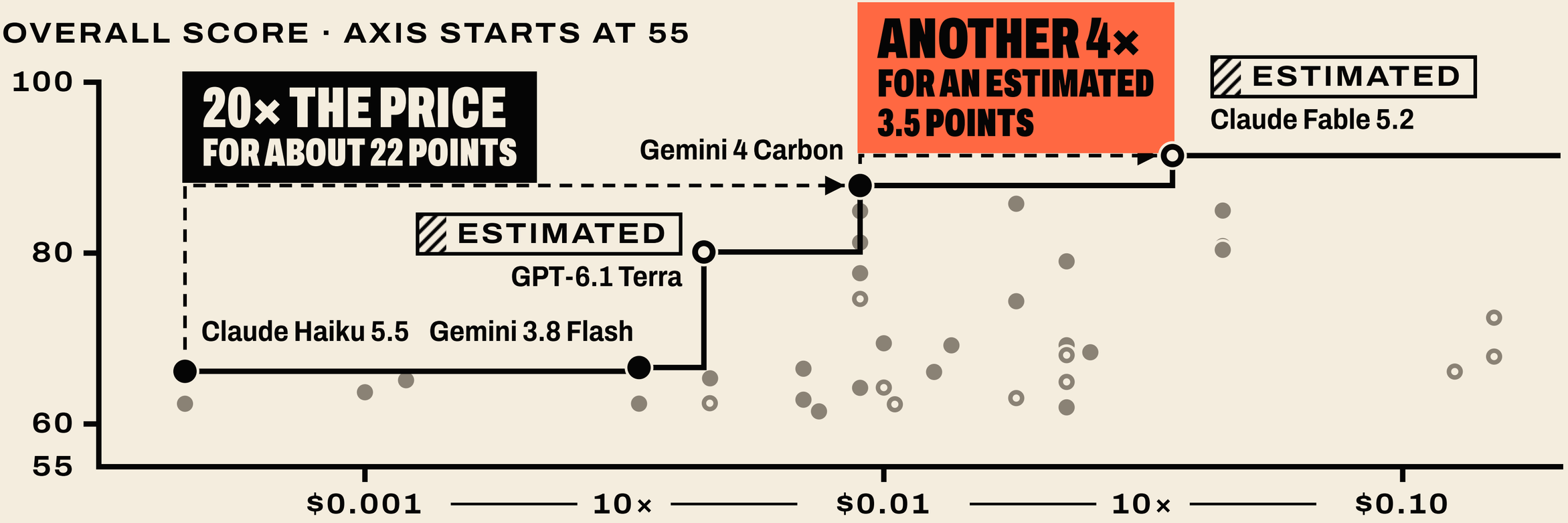
Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · one record = one task = 2,000 tokens in, 500 out

GATE 1 · COST · RECORD SCALE

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

36 OF 41 ARE BEATEN BY SOMETHING THAT COSTS THE SAME OR LESS.

OVERALL SCORE · AXIS STARTS AT 55



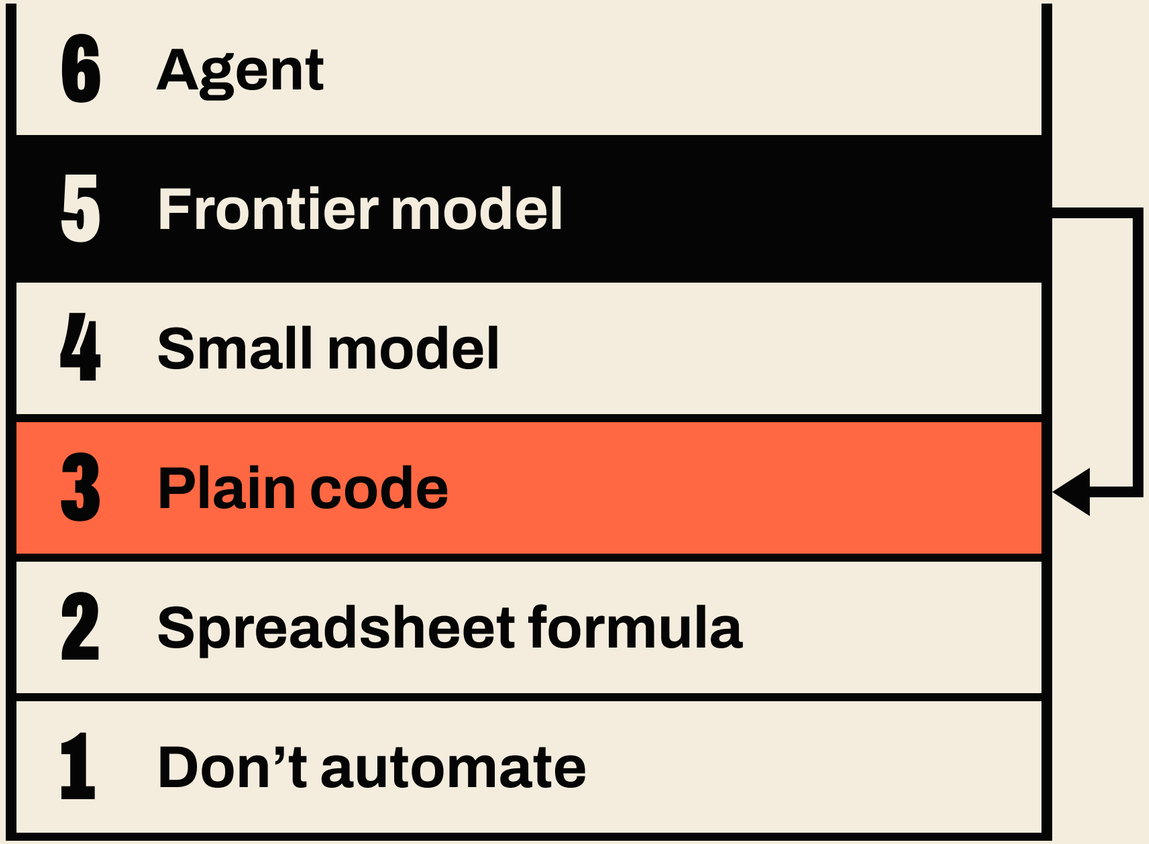
● 5 NOT BEATEN ● 36 BEATEN ○ ESTIMATED PRICE OF ONE TASK · LOG SCALE

Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · the file marks 12 of these 41 scores estimated · rank order is not certain

GATE 1 · COST

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

CLIMB ONLY AS FAR AS THE TASK MAKES YOU.



Use the expensive model once, to write the tool.

Then the tool runs for free.

GATE 2 · RETURN · PRODUCT SIDE

COST | **RETURN** | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

DOES CASH COME IN SOONER?

EXAMPLE THE CASH CONVERSION CYCLE · DAYS · DRAWN TO SCALE



60 + 37 − 30 = 67 days

One day off the cycle frees about one day of sales.

EXAMPLE: A $20M DISTRIBUTOR

≈ $54,800

one day of sales, freed once

Example figures, not Laborde's · 60 days of inventory + 37 to collect − 30 to pay · one day of sales = annual revenue ÷ 365

GATE 2 · RETURN · SERVICE SIDE

COST | **RETURN** | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

Time is money. Literally.

FREED EVERY WEEK · SAME CREW

☐☐☐☐☐☐

0 of 6 hours a week become paid work

PAID WORK · PER YEAR

EXAMPLE

$0

6 h × 50 weeks × $95 margin × **0%**

HOW MUCH OF THE FREED TIME BECOMES PAID WORK?

0%

Zero is also a decision.

Example figures, not Laborde's · 6 freed hours a week × 50 work weeks = 300 hours a year · $95 margin on a billed hour

GATE 2 · RETURN

COST | **RETURN** | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

Does it touch the cash path?

EXAMPLE

QUOTE → ORDER → PICK → SHIP → **INVOICE** → COLLECT

OFF THE PATH · 20 MINUTES SAVED

INTERNAL MEMOS

1	Labor
–	Nothing else

COUNTS ONCE. *Maybe.*

ON THE PATH · 20 MINUTES SAVED

INVOICING

1	Labor
2	Cash sooner

COUNTS TWICE.

The boring idea on the cash path beats the exciting one off it.

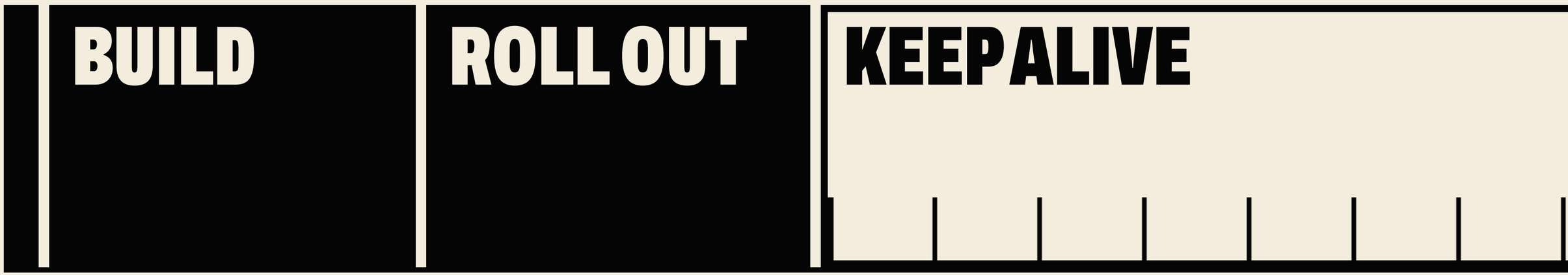
GATE 3 · EFFORT

COST | RETURN | **EFFORT** | POTENTIAL

THE DEMO IS THE CHEAP PART.

ILLUSTRATION, NOT DATA

the demo



Once. Once. Every month.

the part that never ends.

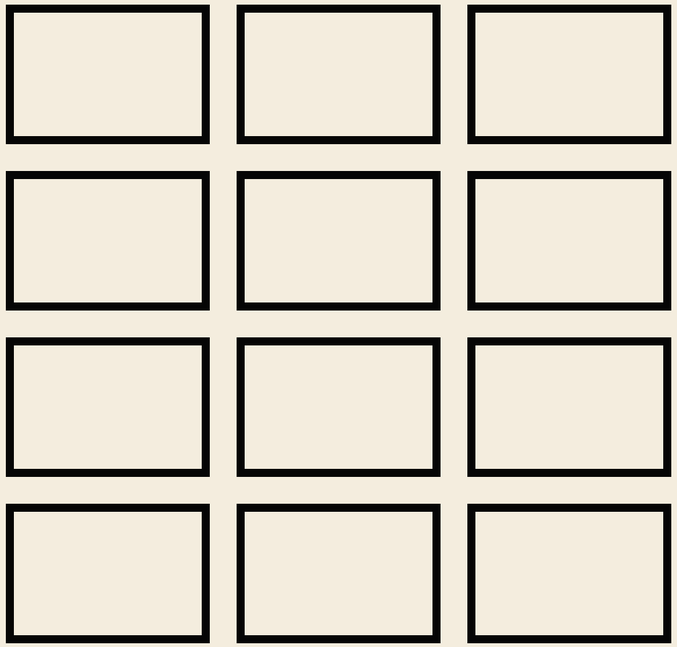
If it works, how far does it grow?

BUILD EFFORT

ONCE

Growth multiplies return, not build effort.

RETURN



ILLUSTRATION, NOT DATA

One site

Three sites

Every team

Who owns the freed time?

LET THE MATH PICK.

RETURN – COST – EFFORT *then grown by* POTENTIAL

A MINUTE A WEEK IS $25 A YEAR.

at $30 an hour · 50 work weeks a year

HOUSE RULES · DEFAULTS · CHANGE THEM

COST	**NO** when yearly cost is more than **30%** of yearly return.
RETURN	**NO** when yearly return is under **$5,000** and it takes no days off the cash cycle.
EFFORT	**NO** when payback is longer than **26** weeks.
POTENTIAL	**NO** when growth is below **1×** or nobody owns the freed time.

EXERCISE 1 · 10 MINUTES

INVENTORY TWO WEEKS OF REAL WORK.

1 What did you do more than twice?

2 What did you copy from one place to another?

3 What did you wait on?

4 What did you dread?

10:00

T start · R reset

EXERCISE 2 · 5 MINUTES

PICK THREE.

1 One you’d love to pitch

2 One that’s boring

3 One you’d be embarrassed to bring up

5:00

T start · R reset

THREE CANDIDATES, FOUR GATES.

EXAMPLE CANDIDATES

A · THE EXCITING ONE
Customer chatbot for parts lookup
NO AT EFFORT

B · THE EASY ONE
Meeting-notes summaries for managers
NO AT COST

C · THE BORING ONE
Invoice follow-up reminders
PASSES ALL FOUR

PASS

GATE 1
COST
$1.35 A YEAR
Under 1% of return

PASS

GATE 2
RETURN
$9,000 A YEAR

PASS

GATE 3
EFFORT
ABOUT 15 WEEKS TO PAY BACK

PASS

GATE 4
POTENTIAL
1.5× GROWTH, OWNER NAMED

PAYS BACK IN
about **15 WEEKS**

WORTH OVER TWO YEARS
about **$17,500**

CASH FREED, ONE TIME
about **$109,600**

Example candidates · time at $30 an hour · building at $75 an hour · cash freed is 2 days of sales (Example: a $20M distributor)

RUN YOUR THREE THROUGH THE GATES. 10:00

RULES	A EXAMPLE	B EXAMPLE	C EXAMPLE
RESET	Customer chatbot for parts lookup	Meeting-notes summaries for managers	Invoice follow-up reminders
COST	PASS — $3,270 a year, 22% of return	NO — $2,880 a year, 58% of return	PASS — $1.35 a year, under 1% of return
RETURN	PASS — $15,000 a year	NOT YET	PASS — $9,000 a year
EFFORT	NO — never pays back	NOT YET	PASS — about 15 weeks to pay back
POTENTIAL	NOT YET	NOT YET	PASS — 1.5× growth, owner named
THE MATH PICKS	Out at Effort	Out at Cost	**$17,547** over two years Frees about $109,600, one time

Minutes saved each time: − 4 +

Times a week: − 150 +

What runs it: $0.036 a run — ‹ Frontier model ›

Tools, a month: − $ 250 +

Build and rollout hours: − 440 +

Upkeep hours a month: − 30 +

Growth over a year: − 1.5 × +

Owner for the freed time: YES / NO

Product or service: PRODUCT / SERVICE

On the cash path: YES / NO

House rules and rates are defaults, yours to change under RULES. A run is 2,000 tokens in, 500 out, at BenchLM prices.

SHARE-OUT · 5 MINUTES

Who killed their favorite?

Who's keeping the boring one?

5:00

T start · R reset

LABORDE PROJECT RECORDS

The winner: where the parts live.

Warehouse slotting. Nobody pitches this.

6,493

parts were moving to a new building.

Every one needed an address.

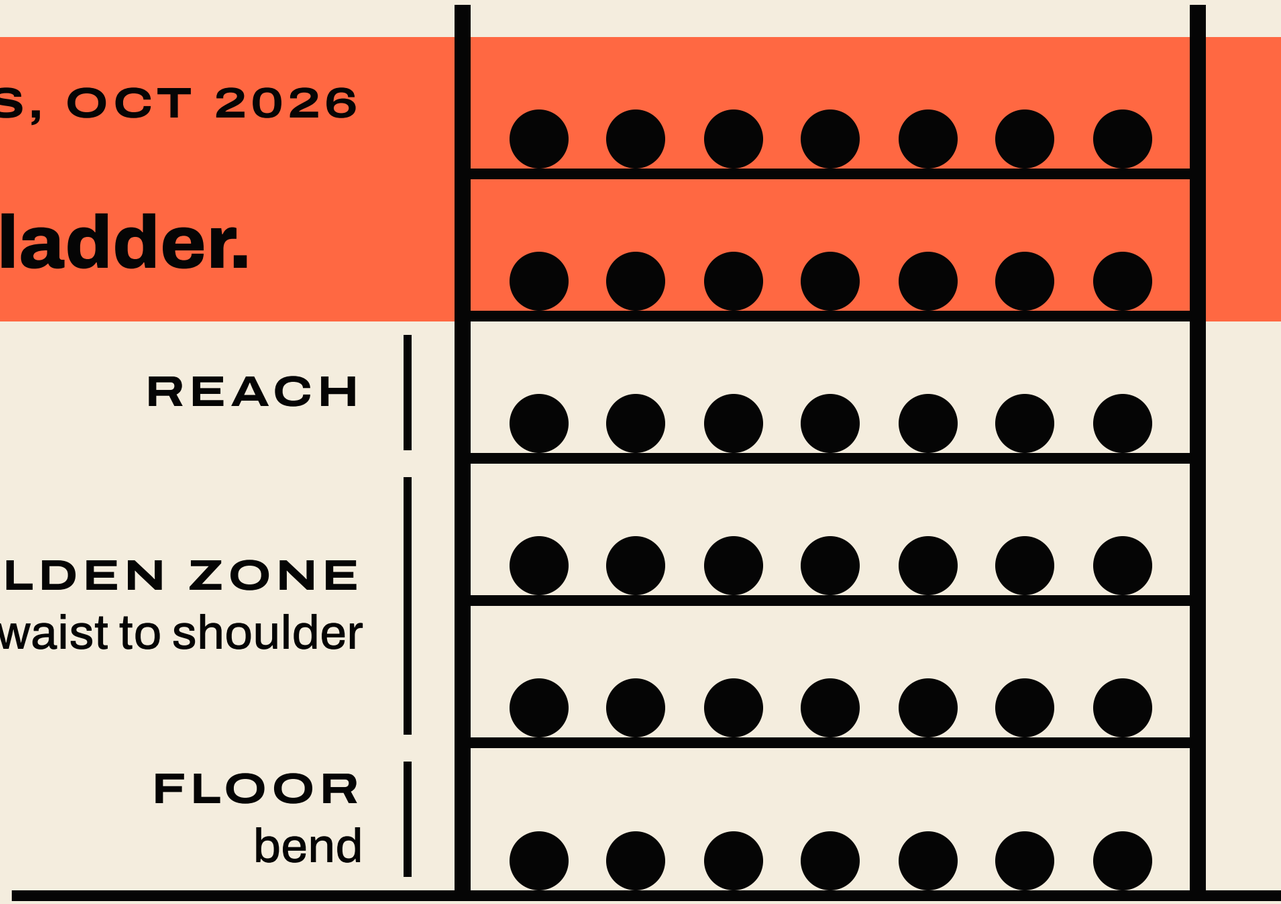
6,493 PARTS. 7,110 SLOTS.

Move them across in their current order and

23%

LABORDE RESULTS, OCT 2026

of picks need a ladder.

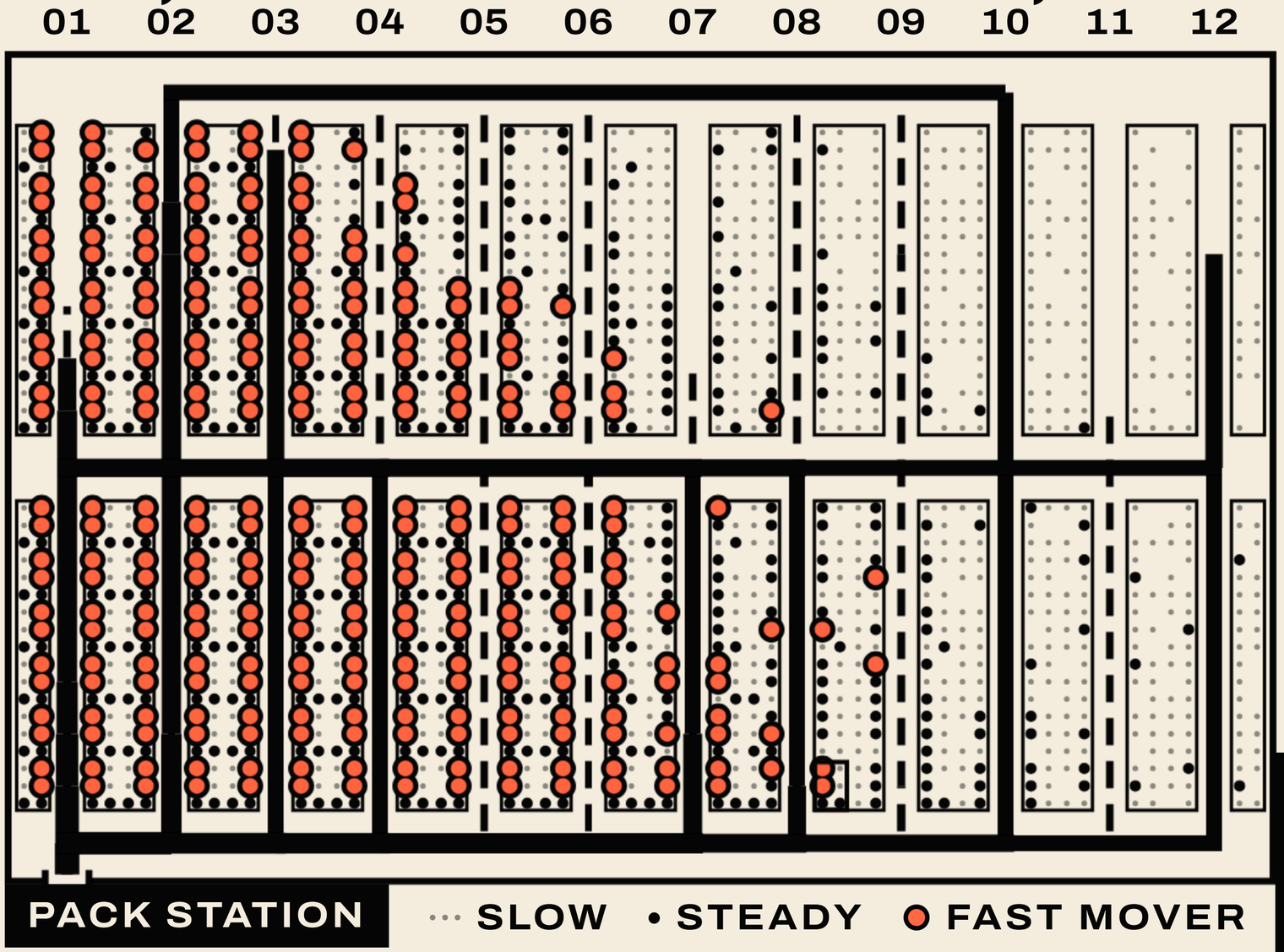


Laborde results, Oct 2026

RACK DRAWING: ILLUSTRATION

ANIMATED RE-CREATION · SYNTHETIC DATA

240,000 SWAPS TRIED IN 1,354 MS.



	AS-IS MOVE	OPTIMIZED
Walk per pick run	291	→ 141 ft
Pick time per year	77.4	→ 27.8 hours
Picks that need a ladder	36%	→ 1.7%
Fast movers in the golden zone	32%	→ 100%

NO AI MODEL IN THE LOOP.

THE REAL NUMBERS.

LABORDE RESULTS, OCT 2026

	AS-IS MOVE		OPTIMIZED	
Walk per pick run	133.6 ft	→	91.1 ft	*31.8% less*
Pick time per year	32.8 hours	→	17.4 hours	*47.0% less*
Picks that need a ladder	23%	→	0.6%	
Fast movers in the golden zone	39%	→	100%	

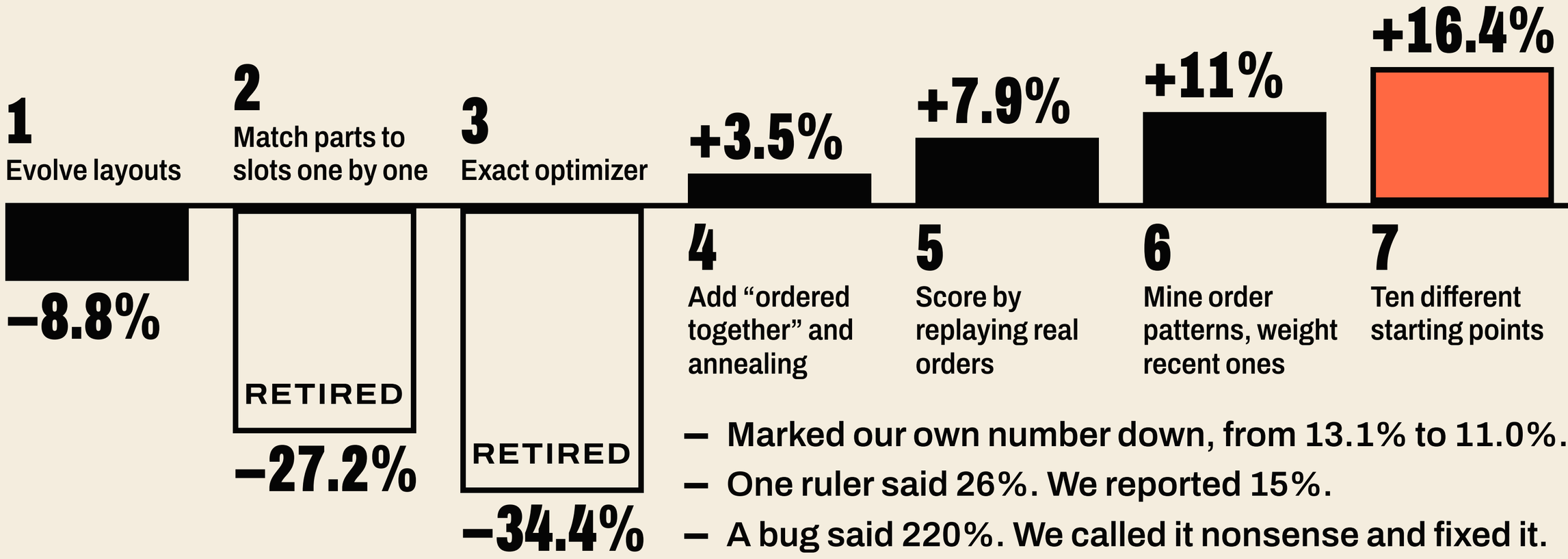
OPTIMIZED, VERSUS THE OLD BUILDING TODAY

12.3% less walking **22.7%** less pick time *In a bigger building.*

Laborde results, Oct 27–28, 2026 · versus moving every part in its current order · pick times are placeholders pending a floor time study
results depend on where the pack station is · the old building's floor plan is estimated

SEVEN ATTEMPTS. THE FIRST THREE LOST TO THE OLD BUILDING.

PERCENT LESS WALKING · ZERO IS THE OLD BUILDING · DRAWN TO SCALE



- Marked our own number down, from 13.1% to 11.0%.
- One ruler said 26%. We reported 15%.
- A bug said 220%. We called it nonsense and fixed it.

The gains came from measuring real orders, not from fancier solvers.

Laborde project records · Walking versus the old building, March 2026 model

WHAT WE SAID NO TO.

LABORDE PROJECT RECORDS

AN AI MODEL IN THE LOOP

It didn’t fit the problem.

NO

A FANCIER SOLVER

Tried two. Both lost.

NO

RE-SLOTTING EVERY MONTH

The move is the one free re-slot.

NO

A $500,000-A-YEAR SAVINGS CLAIM

No source. Excluded.

NO

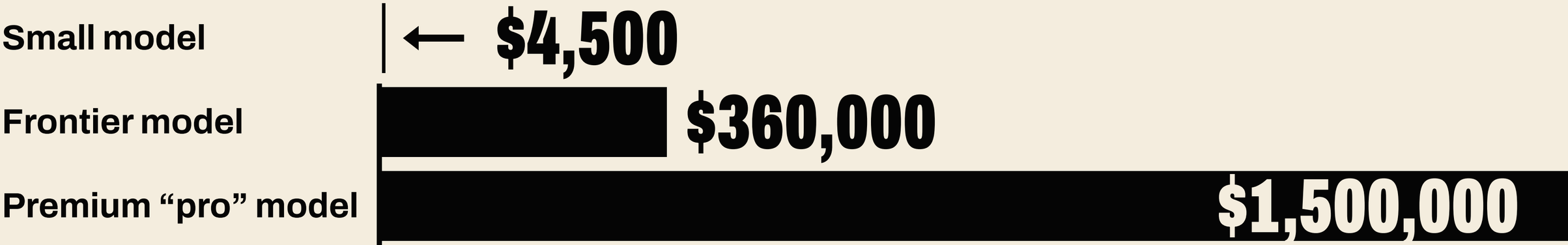
WHAT IT COSTS TO RUN: NOTHING.

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

33 of 47 commits co-written with AI · **0** AI models at run time · **10 million** swaps in about 3.5 minutes

If each of those 10 million tries were a model call:

EXAMPLE · COST OF ONE RUN · US DOLLARS · BARS DRAWN TO SCALE



PLAIN CODE *the electricity.*

The model’s job was to help write the tool. Not to be the tool.

Laborde project records, Mar–Nov 2026 · Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · tiers: Claude Haiku 5.5, Claude Fable 5.2, GPT-5.5 Pro · 2,000 tokens in / 500 out per call

MY OWN PROJECT, THROUGH MY OWN GATES.

Laborde results, Oct 2026
15.4 hours = 32.8 – 17.4 pick hours a year
valued at $30 an hour, an example rate

PASS
COST
$0 to run

CARRIED FORWARD

PASS
RETURN
THE BIGGER RETURN
$19,479 once
The one free re-slot

$7,500 a year
Ladder climbs avoided

NO $462 on minutes alone

PASS $7,962 a year, second run

PASS
EFFORT
PAYS BACK IN
about **22** weeks
40 hours to build
1 hour a month upkeep

CARRIED FORWARD

PASS
POTENTIAL
GROWTH
2×
every future re-slot,
every building

CARRIED FORWARD

ILLUSTRATIVE · CHANGED TO PROTECT COMPANY DATA

The minutes said no.
The move said yes.

We just got the minutes back.

Who owns them?

THE OBJECTION

“My people will just waste the time.”

THAT’S A MANAGEMENT ANSWER. IT ISN’T AN AI PROBLEM.

MY VIEW

SHARE THE GAIN.

1

Name the goal for the freed time

2

Measure it

3

Share the upside

People hide time savings that threaten them. They report the ones they share in.

THE WAYPOINT STANDARD

1	2	3	4
THE TASK	THE PROMPT	THE OUTPUT	THE TIME SAVED

If you can’t show all four, it didn’t happen.

MONDAY MORNING.

1 Inventory two weeks.

2 Run three through the gates.

3 Say **NO** twice.

"A few first rate
~~research papers~~ **AI PROJECTS** OUR EDIT
are preferable to a large number
that are poorly conceived
or half-finished."

— CLAUDE SHANNON, THE BANDWAGON, 1956

SAY NO TO THE EXCITING.
SAY YES TO THE MATH.

SAY NO TO THE EXCITING.
SAY YES TO THE MATH.

WAYPOINT · NOAI 2026 · NEW ORLEANS

Thank you.

Questions.

DECK AND CODE

MONDAY MORNING

1. Inventory two weeks.
2. Run three through the gates.
3. Say no twice.

Dustin T Hughes

VP of Technology, Laborde Products

github.com/hughes-research/nolaai-2026